

Board Work Session - September 30, 2020 - Mark Dosen Comments on Returning To 5-Day

Please bear with me as I decided to write out my thoughts to not miss anything. After this meeting, I will post my comments in BoardDocs for reference and transparency.

I want to start by thanking all our families for taking the time and effort to respond to our survey and for sending us your personal emails sharing your thoughts, concerns, questions and feedback. Collectively, this represents the voice of our community and it provided the board with a comprehensive view of our families' opinions and experiences.

Not surprisingly, there were very strong and passionate feelings for both retaining hybrid as well as switching to 5-day in-person. Despite where we land as a board tonight, our decision will be greeted with satisfaction and joy by some and disappointment and anger by others. Personally, I have felt the weight of this decision since it was brought to us last week. Please know that your board has made their best effort to consider a wide range of opinions and inputs in order to provide a direction that we believe will be in the best interest of our district.

On August 3rd this board discussed whether to follow the guidance of the Cuyahoga County Board of Health which recommended all districts within the county begin the year remotely. Based on numerous factors including the low spread rate within our community, we boldly decided to be one of the few districts to return our students to in-person learning albeit via a hybrid model.

I expressed concerns about this newly conceived hybrid model and preferred instead a return to a full 5-day model right from the start. Ultimately, the board chose hybrid.

I want to thank our superintendent for having the courage to bring us her recommendation so quickly into the start of our school year. Her observations that the hybrid model is falling far short of expectations, especially for some of our youngest learners, led her to act quickly in proposing a change. We stated from the beginning that COVID is a fluid situation and that change could come quickly as circumstances unfold.

When completing this survey, our parents were able to draw on more data than they had a few months ago. Our county has been in level 2 orange for six straight weeks, high school sports, band and extracurriculars have returned with minimal COVID impact and parents had the opportunity to see first-hand what our hybrid model is like.

From our survey, if you filter out those who responded, "I am an online learner", here's the revised breakdown:

- 34% - Stay in the hybrid model through Thanksgiving Break
- 62% - Move to 5 day in-person instruction on October 26th
- 4% - I am currently an online learner, but would like to switch to 5-day, in-person learning

This means 66% want to move to a 5-day model compared to 34% who want to remain in the hybrid model. This represents a significant 32-point spread. It is clear a vast majority of our parents are aligned with our superintendent's recommendation to end the hybrid experiment and return to a conventional 5-day in-person model.

I realize that such a change in the middle of the semester would be highly disruptive for students, families and staff. Those hybrid students who are uncomfortable with the 5-day model and would need to switch to online would lose out on in-person experiences two days a week. Families who made arrangements to accommodate the hybrid schedule would once again need to adjust. While I am troubled by the negative consequences from making a switch, we also cannot stick with an educational model that is clearly not working for most of our families. Therefore, just as I expressed last August, I support the return to a 5-day model.

Shifting to a 5-day model will afford us an opportunity to settle in now and improve the delivery of both online and in-person education this semester. It will position us well for next semester as parents will have a much better grasp on the pros and cons of 5-day versus online.

In closing, this is a COVID year and it sucks. Education has suffered and will continue to suffer while COVID is with us. However, we need to learn to live with this virus and adapt. It is time to join the many schools across the country who are making the 5-day model work. Thank you all for your patience as we figure out the best path forward for the Brecksville-Broadview Heights School District.

Survey Results

90 I am currently an online learner, but would like to switch to 5-day, in-person learning
1394 Move to 5 day in-person instruction on October 26th
777 Stay in the hybrid model through Thanksgiving Break
188 I am an all online learner

2403 Total

Remove "I am an all online learner" from the total
 $1394 + 90 + 777 = 2261$

Calculate revised percentages

$(1394 + 90) / 2261 = 66\%$ Move to 5-day
 $777 / 2261 = 34\%$ Stay in hybrid

Currently, my child is enrolled in:

In-person Hybrid 2144
Online learning 259

Currently, there is a mandatory ALL remote period built into the current school calendar between November 30, 2020 through December 18, 2020 to allow for deep cleaning of the buildings and to be proactive to reduce the spread of flu in addition to COVID. Please choose from the following options:

1432 Continue with the learning model that the district is in prior to the break
712 Keep that period of time ALL remote

2144 Total

$1432 / 2144 = 67\%$ Continue with learning model after break
 $712 / 2144 = 33\%$ Stay ALL remote